MEMBERS OF THE ALLEGED CARTEL

P. SARATH CHANDRA REDDY, *Promoter-director, Aurobindo, Hyderabad*





K. KAVITHA, *MLC, TRS, Telangana*

MAGUNTA SRINIVASULU REDDY, *MP, YSRC, Andhra Pradesh,* family in liquor business for seven decades spread over 8 states



ABHISHEK BOINPALLY, *beauty salon chain (Anoo's Parlour) owner,* Hyderabad, and son of TRS founding member B. Hanumantha Rao

ARUN RAMACHANDRAN PILLAI, *promoter, Robin Distribution LLP,* Hyderabad, along with Boinpally

six times between December 2021 and August 2022, and four times between September 2021 and August 2022 for the number 8985699999, to destroy evidence. In August, BJP MP Parvesh Varma and former MLA Manjinder Singh Sirsa had sought to link her to the scam. Terming the allegations "completely baseless", Kavitha filed a defamation case in the City Civil Court in Hyderabad, which, in an interim order, directed BJP leaders not to make defamatory statements against her. Now with the ED bringing up destruction of evidence, Kavitha joins a list of "36 suspects/ accused" who the ED says destroyed 176 cell phones and laptops after the case was handed over to the agency.

She seems as unfazed as any veteran. Alleging the BJP has all agencies in its grip, Kavitha says she will cooperate with any investigation thrown her way. "The BJP is trying to tarnish our party's reputation by associating my name with the scam," she says. "We have thoroughly exposed the BJP's plot to destabilise the TRS government." The inclusion of her name in the Arora remand report is the BJP's revenge for that, she says. Kavitha is here referring to the alleged attempt by three men to poach four TRS MLAs in Hyderabad. Shortly before the Munugode bypoll, the TRS released a video in which the trio, allegedly engaged by the BJP, were heard trying to poach a TRS MLA. Crucially, the recordings named B.L. Santhosh, BJP national general secretary. And a Special Investigating Team (SIT) appointed by the state government on the directions of the Telangana High Court told the court that one of the three accused, Ramachandra Bharati, was in constant touch with Santhosh. Though BJP leaders say Kavitha's role in the Delhi scam was to come out any time, the remand report coincided with the SIT submitting its report to the high court.

In that report, the SIT submitted details of WhatsApp calls, phone calls, messages and voice notes exchanged between the accused, and cited documentary evidence, including photographs and cell tower locations of the accused. The most important 'conspiracy meeting' allegedly took place on October 15 at Santhosh's government quarters. It was attended by Bharath Dharma Jana Sena chief Tushar Vellapally, and two of the accused—Kore Nandu Kumar and Bharati. The high court has granted a stay, now extended till December 12, on the SIT notice issued to Santhosh under Section 41A of the CrPC.

The charges and counter-charges are certain to leave both sides bruised. "If the BJP goes the whole hog against the TRS, it too will be hurt," says Harathi Vageeshan, political science professor, NALSAR University of Law. "Kavitha will now be projected as a victim, despite public perception that it's her appetite for riches that prompted KCR to keep her low-key since 2018." Already, KCR was feeling cornered after the fright in Munugode, where its candidate staved off the BJP challenge only by a narrow margin. The crisis reaching Code Orange levels is not a happy prospect just months before an assembly election. ■

By Romita Datta

With panchayat elections in West Bengal scheduled in March 2023—expected to be a curtain-raiser for the parliamentary election in 2024—the BJP has been looking high and low for a credible Bengali face to woo rural voters. Finally, they have decided to pin their hopes on Mithun Chakraborty: movie star, entrepreneur, philanthropist and neophyte politician. However, the real reason for its choice lies in Mithun's unparalleled demotic pull in his home state. The 72-year-old is performing the role assigned to him with all seriousness—talking up the saffron party, sitting down for humble meals in tribal homes and making a mouthful of promises, like "incredible investment" coming Bengal's way if the BJP is voted to power. Mithun was inducted into the state BJP's 20-member core committee in October. The effort to project Mithun in a big way began a few months back—he was flown in to inaugurate Durga Pujas patronised by the BJP in various districts, including in North Bengal.

Though Mithun's presence has attracted moderate attention and crowds, the party is having a tough time explaining his various gaffes. For instance, his statement about the need for a grand alliance or *mahajot* of opposition parties (probably implying a rather improbable alliance of the CPI-M, Congress and BJP) as the only means to counter the Trinamool Congress government has left everyone confused. State BJP president Sukanta Majumdar and party MP Dilip Ghosh have openly dismissed such possibilities. Then, too, over the past months, Mithun has harped on about TMC MLAs who wanted to join the BJP being in touch with him. The turncoats have failed to materialise.

Though Mithun's earlier stint as the party's star cam-